caffè misto

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/28241220.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

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Alternate Universe - Coffee Shops & Cafés, Fluff, One Shot, Exes, Getting Back Together, Catra is a passive aggressive cat who doesn't know how to have conversations, Modern AU but still Canon Species

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Summary

Adora finds her ex working at the coffee shop near her internship. She should leave Catra alone, but instead she finds herself going there at every opportunity, drinking whatever weird concoction Catra replaces her order with in the hopes of reconnecting.
(Catradora modern coffee shop AU)

Notes

I've never written a coffee shop AU before? I read the N-Sync fic believed to be responsible for the trend, but I never really got the appeal myself. I couldn't resist Catra fucking with Adora's drink, though.

See the end of the work for more notes

Adora could just change her coffee shop. Glimmer doesn't understand why she would keep *going* to the same shop her ex works at. Glimmer never knew Adora before college though. She met her exactly a month after their breakup. She doesn't know Catra or understand why Adora would climb mountains for her. Or in this case, drink wrong or outright *gross* coffee for her.

The cafe on campus got its license revoked for a health code violation – which was *very* comforting for the state of the cafeteria – and her work's coffee is so shit Adora would prefer to skip it. So here she is, getting coffee at the Starbucks across from her internship's office every day she is off-campus, and running into Catra two days a week.

She is pretty sure Catra thinks Adora is trying to torture her, seeing as she can't *escape* when Adora corners her at work. The incorrect orders are revenge for Adora talking to her when she has to smile and nod, because Catra is more than aware that while Adora may complain to *her* about them, she would never go to a manager or risk endangering her job.

Adora raises a brow at Catra when she hands over her drink. Catra's face is blank, a perfect mask of a meaningless interaction between a service employee and a customer. Adora takes the cup from her and cautiously takes a sip.

Well, it is a caffeine, so she'll give Catra that. It has *raspberry syrup added*, but it is at least her order this time. It also, surprisingly, isn't that gross. Catra definitely did something other stuff to it, balancing the sugar or something, but Adora doesn't have refined enough of a palate – or extensive enough knowledge of the menu – to know what those changes were.

Despite having a poker face on, Adora sees a little of the light in Catra's eyes dull at her reaction. Apparently she thought Adora would retch or something. Adora raises an eyebrow and takes a long drink.

"Tolerable," she admits, though she would never order it herself. Catra clearly tried to make her something gross, but she put effort into cutting it a *little*. Maybe she just isn't willing to push Adora too far. Adora would rather jump in traffic than complain about Catra to her manager, but Catra doesn't trust people, and she probably isn't willing to rely on that.

It was why they broke up, after all. Catra was sure Adora would cheat on her when she went away for a different university than her. The lack of trust hurt Adora, and by the time the summer before college hit, Catra was blocking her number. Adora was fucking heartbroken that the girl she was *in love with* didn't trust her.

Apparently Catra ended up here anyway. It has been three years, a lot could have changed, but Adora isn't really sure how to find out *what* when the only interaction she gets with Catra is a *hmph* before she turns back to the register to get her next order.

Adora is still going to keep trying. She isn't sure *what* she is trying, but three years changes a lot. Catra might not have been as serious about the relationship as Adora was, but if she can have Catra in her life again, even as a friend, she will take it.

She just has to figure out how to go from *barista* to *friend* when Catra wants nothing to do with her.

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You would think peppermint and toffee would be good, right? Adora would - at least, until she tasted it. No, there is *definitely* something else in there. *Complicated* is the only way she knows how to describe the flavour. She looks to Catra, who is doing a decent job of tamping down her amusement at watching Adora force down the drink, but it isn't working on Adora.

"Peppermint, tofee, and what else?" she gives up, with a sigh. Catra seems to enjoy making Adora guess as much as she enjoys making Adora *drink it*. Catra scoffs.

"You think too *small*, Adora," she chides, a grin slowly spreading up her face. No one else is in line, and Catra's fellow barista ducked into the back right when Catra started making her drink. Catra has all the time in the world to enjoy the chaos she has reaped. Catra raises her hand and begins counting off additions with her fingers.

"Black coffee, eggnog, pumpkin spice, peppermint syrup, toffee nut syrup, a splash of coconut milk, and an added shot of espresso to counterbalance all that *sugar* you're drinking, princess," Catra tells her with a wicked grin. Adora looks down at her cup. She will admit to never paying attention to how her coffee is made before – and seeing as Catra hasn't done it correct once she can't *start now* – but she thinks she should have noticed Catra adding all that.

"Doesn't this stuff cost extra? Couldn't you get in trouble for just giving it to customers to fuck with them?" Adora asks. Secretly, she is just glad it isn't the pineapple-ginger syrup again. That coffee had been rough. Catra levels her with an incredibly unimpressed look.

"You think the manager is going to notice an extra pump? Don't be stupid, Adora. Go to your work or whatever," Catra tells her, rolling her eyes. Adora pouts, hesitating a moment, but *trapping* Catra after she already told her to leave isn't going to endear her to her ex. After a moment, she sends Catra a small wave and follows her instructions.

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Catra doesn't even fix her a coffee this time. Adora places her order, walks to the end of the counter, and finds Catra shoving an already-

ade latte at her . Adora blinks at her, but she takes it.

"Really? Y ou're not even going to pretend?" Adora asks, raising an eyebrow at Catra over the edge of the cup as she takes a sip. It is a perfectly norm al latte. A bit too sweet for Adora' s tastes, but Catra didn't put in any weird flavourings or anything. Adora has no clue why she is giving her *this* drink. Catra scowls at her, her tail lashing, but there are no custom ers behind Adora at the mom ent to give her an excuse to escape.

"I added one-too-m any pum ps of caram el to it and the custom er freaked about watching her diet. If you drink it, I didn't waste it at least," Catra tells her , sniffing dism issively as she turns back to wiping down one of the m achines. Adora blinks at her . She has no idea if this is a food waste thing – both of them have pretty big issues with that, growing up dirt poor like they did – or if Catra could actually get in trouble for having to m ake an extra cof fee, but either way the latte is fine and Adora is happy to drink it.

She shrugs, opening her m outh to *tell* Catra that, but at that mom ent another custom er com es up to order and Catra walks away from her .

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Adora is being run ragged by m idterm s. She knows she doesn't look her *best*, but she has tried to look professional for work and *alive* for Catra. Not that Catra cares as Adora tries to engage in conversation with her. She is m aking Adora' s drink, and Adora *really* should be paying attention, but she can't help noticing that Catra seem s tired herself.

"Midterm s are a bitch, huh?" Adora asks her . Com m iserating, but it will also tell her whether Catra is still in school. Adora got a scholarship to Bright Moon University – Catra didn't. She could still

go to the state school on free tuition for foster kids, but that is an hour away. There are a few other colleges in the area that are smaller than BMU, but most of them are specialized in a particular field like engineering.

Catra snorts as she puts the lid on Adora's drink. She shoots Adora an unimpressed look.

"Astute observation," she returns. It isn't a clear answer, it is a little mocking, and Adora can't help but feel it is a carefully selected dodge to avoid letting her in to any part of Catra's life again. Before Adora can ask any more questions, Catra breezes away to take her next order. The lizardfolk behind Adora shoots her a dirty look for holding up the line, and Adora is forced to shuffle out of the store. She doesn't try her drink until she is out of the street.

It is a café latte, for the most part, but she thinks it was made with almond milk and heavy cream

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Adora takes a sip and fights not to pull a face. It *is* her order - but it is bitter as shit. She looks over the counter at Catra. Amusement is already dancing in her eyes. Adora sighs. Catra has *never* served her the correct order, but she hasn't added peppermint syrup or anything in a while. Adora was *hopeful* that her casual chatter while Catra fixes her drinks was getting through, but apparently not.

"What did you do to it this time?" she asks, fighting not to pull a face. She doesn't want anyone noticing and asking questions. Getting Catra in trouble is *not* going to help them rebuild any bridges.

"What? You looked *tired*. Most people don't complain about free espresso shots, princess," Catra returns, *delight* in her voice. Adora

looks down at the coffee in her hand. Apparently Catra is having a boring morning if fucking with Adora is bringing her this much joy.

The coffee really is *too much*. Adora can take extra sugar, but this much bitterness is just not drinkable for her. At least Catra is having fun. She resigns herself to the shitty filter coffee in her office for the morning. When she makes it outside the store, she chucks the coffee in the trash can out front. It is a waste of three dollars – it always is – but seeing Catra happy like that was worth it at least.

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The next time Adora comes in, the store is unusually busy for a Thursday morning, but the holidays are rapidly coming up, so maybe more people are coming in for the seasonal flavours. Catra is flying between orders, and she doesn't even make eye contact with Adora when she hands her the drink, already calling out another order as she turns away.

Adora hovers awkwardly, feeling disappointment run through her before she sighs and gives up on getting a chat in today. She leaves the crowded store, sipping her drink, and almost does a doubletake when she realizes it is *right*.

Catra wouldn't even *look* at her, though. This – has to just be because she had so many orders. She didn't want to fuck with the wrong one of accident, or maybe didn't have time to come up with something to do to Adora's.

Adora's heart is hammering a little in her chest. She turns back to look inside the coffee shop. Catra is in the process of turning away, preparing to make another order. For a brief moment, their eyes meet, and then Catra is right back to work.

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Adora lets out a soft noise of surprise when she tries her drink. It isn't a caffeine-to-go – at least not a regular one - but it is *delicious*. It tastes like a holiday candle, rich toffee and spices. Adora hums happily, shooting Catra a side-eye as she lowers her drink.

"Alright, what is that? Is it holiday-exclusive?" she asks, knowing she is still grinning. Catra made her something *nice*. Catra's ear twitches and she shrugs, looking away.

"It's not a menu item. Something I came up with and wanted a guinea pig to try it on," Catra tells her, dismissive and uninterested. Adora feels her side fall a little bit. She nods curtly. Catra was still at least *hoping* the drink would be good. She was just putting Adora's tongue on the line if it wasn't. Adora tries to tell herself not to be disappointed.

Part of her doesn't even know why she is trying so hard. Catra *dumped* her. Catra wasn't in love like Adora was, clearly, and she doesn't care *now* like Adora does. To her, this is just her annoying ex coming in to bother her at work and having the decency to let her have some fun with it. Catra might even have a new girlfriend now.

Adora's stomach kind of feels like lead now. She leaves with her heart heavy in her chest.

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There is literally *no one else* in the entire store. Catra frequently has a co-worker with her, but today it is just her and Adora, likely on

account of the blizzard outside. Catra stares at her incredulously as Adora pushes the café's door open.

"*It's a snowstorm, Adora*," she hisses as Adora smiles hopefully at her. *They are alone*. Adora approaches the counter, shaking the snowflakes from her hair.

"Internship never sent out stay-home emails, so I'm here. Any your first customer today?" Adora asks, leaning against the counter and throwing Catra her best winning smile. Catra, to her surprise, flushes and twitches her ears.

"No one else has been stupid enough to come out. I'm supposed to close the store early if people don't start coming in," Catra tells her, eyeing Adora's coat. Adora knows it is a bit thin for this weather, but it is the warmest thing she owns.

"Hey, if I didn't come out, I wouldn't get to see you," Adora points out. Catra's eyes go wide for a moment before she quickly darts them away. Adora hears her tail thud against the cabinets, but she can't see it lash over the counter. She bites her lip, wondering if that was good or bad.

She can't get a read on Catra with the counter between them. She can't tell if Catra is being nice because she has to, or *indifferent* because she has to. Her best indicator is the way Catra fucks with her drink, since no one else is aware of that form of communication between them, but the problem is it seems to be all over the place, even if Catra's additions have trends to them.

"You need to stop drinking so much coffee," is what Catra returns with. Adora feels her heart fall into her stomach. Ice spreads out from her heart, right into her throat. She gets the message. Catra hasn't been able to be this blunt with her coworkers and customers around, but she can be clear now. Breathing is a bit hard, but Adora manages to clear her throat.

"Right. I'll- leave you alone. I'm sorry for bothering you," she manages, a bit clipped, but she is so *defeated*. All semester she has been trying and all Catra has done is push her away, just like she did the first time. Adora's heart *trips* when she sees Catra, but the breakup should have been the hint she needed to know Catra has never felt the same.

Catra startles a little at her words, her eyes snapping up, but Adora *can't* do this. She really used to think Catra loved her too. It *seemed* like it in high school, but even after three years, Catra still wants Adora out of her life. Adora turns, striding toward the door quickly, her heart pounding in her ears.

"*Adora*," Catra calls from behind her. Despite herself, Adora's step falters. She got the message, she really doesn't want it *clarified*. Maybe Catra is just worried about a bad review, or something. As if Adora ever would.

"Adora, I was going to say you don't *have* to buy a coffee to talk to me," Catra adds, her voice a bit soft. Adora's heart is in her *throat* now as she turns back around. Catra is shooting her a look tense with nerves, exasperation, and fondness. From behind the machines, she produces a café latte, still steaming. Even from here Adora can make out the messy scrawl of Catra's lettering on the side of the cup, her number written out.

Adora knows the hope must be blatant on her face from the way Catra rolls her eyes and holds the cup further out. Adora crosses the shop, taking the coffee with slightly-trembling hands. She swallows thickly as she looks down at the number. It is different than the one Catra used to have – local.

"I've missed you," she whispers, glancing up nervously. Catra flushes, looking away as her ears twitch. Give Adora an inch, and she will take a mile. Catra knows this – at least she did *once*.

"Yeah, whatever, the feeling's mutual. Just fucking *text* me. Go to work. I don't want to do this in the café," Catra tells her, still not

looking Adora in the eye. Despite the dismissal, Adora's heart soars, and she practically *bounces* out of the shop.

When she sips her coffee, it is a caffeinistto, perfectly prepared.

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Adora forces herself to wait until her break to text Catra a tenuous greeting.

Honestly expected sooner. You've lost your touch.

Hon break. Tomorrow?

And there is that eagerness Iexpected. It's a date.

Adora looks down at her phone screen, her heart pounding. When Catra pushed her away, Adora kind of felt like her life was over. No matter what has happened since then, all the good things she has now, a part of her has always planned on returning to her hometown and trying to find Catra again.

And yet here she is, in Adora's new city, *going on a date with her again.* Here she is giving Adora ways to reach out, after passive-aggressively fucking with her for months. Which actually just sounds like normal Catra behaviour, but Adora had just about given up hope on themgetting to be *friends* like that again.

--

Catra meets her at a restaurant, a small indie place near campus, and they just *catchup*. Neither of them mentions the breakup, and Adora doesn't even ask about the way Catra has been fucking with her coffee, even though she *really* wants to.

Catra went to their hometown community college, apparently , and just came to the city last year for her four-year degree. She is going to the financial college down the street from the coffee shop – which maybe Adora should have *guessed* – and next year she will graduate with her accounting degree.

"Still the certification to go through, but I'm close. I won't have to work part-time jobs anymore," she tells Adora, rolling her eyes. The lighting in the restaurant is a bit dim, and Catra's eyes dance in the light. Adora tells Catra about what she has been up to with school, her internship, and her new friends. It almost feels like a first date, if Adora didn't know what Catra's lips taste like and the soft melody of her moans.

Adora is fucking terrified when they leave the restaurant, doing her best not to cling to Catra's hand. Catra rolls her eyes, stepping close and cradling Adora's cheek to guide her down into a chaste goodnight kiss.

"You have my number ," Catra reminds her as she pulls away .

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It is a café visit. It almost always is these days. Sometimes Catra still fucks with her for fun, but she never makes her something inedible anymore. Adora grins as her girlfriend hands her the drink, and Catra just rolls her eyes and shoos her out of the store.

They text all the time. If one of them isn't in class or working, they are on the phone together, entwining their lives again. All it took was Catra admitting on their third date that the real reason she broke up with Adora had nothing to do with trusting her.

"I would have trusted you with my fucking life, Adora. I just hated myself so much I didn't think it was possible for anyone to stay with me once they got some distance," Catra told her, not looking at the heartbroken expression spreading over Adora's face. It was hard to hear that Catra felt that way – that she still does sometimes – but when it came time to transfer schools, there was no question about which city she was headed to.

She wasn't ready to seek Adora out yet, but it didn't matter, because the universe brought them together over caf first, properly prepared.

"Why were you fucking with my coffee?" Adora asks one evening, when they are laying together on Catra's couch. They still have to work on their relationship, but Catra tastes exactly how Adora remembers, so they can figure it out. Catra snorts at her words, shooting her a fond look.

"I still needed to convince myself you could care, and I wanted to show you I trusted you. If you complained, I would have been fired. I knew you wouldn't. Besides, it was *fun* making you drink the weird combinations I could come up with," Catra tells her. Adora blinks at her. It is the most ass-backwards logic she has ever heard, but it is *very* Catra. She snorts, wrapping her arms around Catra and snuggling into the warm fluff of her winter coat. Catra purrs in response, wriggling a bit on the couch cushions.

"None of them were supposed to be *bad,* by the way. It is hard to guess what tastes good when it is too sugary for me to try myself. I guessed based off the scent," Catra tells her. Adora blinks in surprise, raising her head. Catra sinks a little. "Not that they were always supposed to be *good*, but that was part of the *showing trust* thing," she adds. Yeah, that sounds more in line with the *pineapple-*

ginger drink. Adora rolls her eyes, a fond smile tugging at the edge of her mouth.

"You're emotionally stunted," she tells Catra. That is not how people show trust, at least usually. Catra snorts and shoots her a bemused look.

"So are you. At least I'm not an idiot," Catra tells her. Adora huffs, but she nuzzles down into her girlfriend. Catra's grades are better than hers, and she is not likely to ever hear the end of *that*, but she doesn't care. She loves being the subject of Catra's teasing again and knowing it is loving.

Catra's affection is worth every shitty, over-flavoured coffee she could ever drink.

End Notes

Tomorrow's advent fic (because apparently that's a thing I'm doing now) should be the final installment in the roommates series if I can get it finished in time. After that it is canon fics work about a week and then my new multi-chapter will start up!

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!